

7,995. The performance was very close to that of the Samsung S850. It secures second place, a little ahead of the Canon PowerShot A460. These two are pretty much the same except for the zoom. The A460 has 4x optical zoom, as compared to the 3x of the A450. The price difference is about Rs. 500.

A major disappointment here was Nikon. The L10 and the L11 are almost identical in terms of specs and also in performance as we tested them.

The performance isn't spectacular, but if you're looking for a very compact camera, look at the Sony W55.

THE CREAM OF THE CROP (RS 15,001 TO RS 25,000)

This group is dominated by Canon. Then there are Sony and Samsung cameras, as well as a lone Kodak.

Design

Samsung's i70 has a neat sliding mechanism similar to cell phones. Push the back panel to the left and it slides smoothly into place, and turns itself on. The buttons are flat and don't give any feedback. The zoom is controlled by similarly-designed buttons.

Although the Canon TX1's vertical design is well-suited for camcorder-like use, it's not quite perfect. The index finger ends up where the camera's lens pops out. The battery slot panel is way too flimsy. The foldable 1.8-inch screen is too tiny for you to be able to make out anything. The camera does have a sturdy feel to it, with fat, chunky buttons for recording, including a dedicated button for recording video.

The screen on the Canon A640 is connected to a hinge that allows you to rotate it freely. This is particularly useful in turning the screen on



Samsung S850
Quality zoom but not the best design

its back and protecting it from scratches when not in use. The complaint about the A640 is the four AA batteries needed. The A640, although very well-built, is one of the heaviest cameras we tested.

The other well-built camera here is the titanium-body Canon IXUS 900 Ti, which is particularly compact.

The Kodak V1003 looks like its sibling, the V803, from the earlier category. It has similar smooth curves and a good glossy finish.

Both the Sony cameras—the W90 and the T100—are well-designed, flat cameras that can fit in a shirt pocket. The menus have the new user-friendly look, grey with orange highlighted icons and smoother fonts—some of the nicest-looking menus.

Features

The Canon TX1 is unique; it doubles up as a good HD camcorder, and can record video at 1280 x 720 (720p). You would require a sizeable memory card to be able to record a video of decent length. The quality of the video isn't particularly great, it must be said.

Controlling the Samsung i7 is the ultimate in ease; it has a touchscreen that allows you to select a displayed feature and proceed to more advanced options within that feature. This is a happy departure from the multiple button-press sequences to do the simplest of tasks.

Features like image stabilisation and face detection were present on most of the cameras; the Kodak V1003 and the Canon A640 missed out.

Unfortunately, only the Canon A710 IS, A640, and the A570 IS have manual focus.

Performance

Canon's top line-up performed very well in general. Some of the best macros we shot throughout the test were with the Canon A640, A710 IS

The Sony Cyber-shot DSC H7

In addition to what we've reviewed above, we also received the Sony DSC H7—a slightly different breed of digital camera, one that lies between a point-and-shoot camera and a digital SLR. Some people call such cameras pseudo-SLRs or semi-SLRs; some others call them ultrazooms. They do look very similar to SLRs, but are smaller.

The H7, like most other cameras of its kind, gives one complete manual control as well as semi-automated settings like the Aperture and Shutter priority, which allow you to set a fixed aperture and shutter speed—the camera changes the others parameters accordingly for proper photos.

Whereas most point-and-shoot cameras are stuck with 3x to 4x zoom, the DSC H7 is an 8MP camera with a tremendous 15x optical zoom (31 to 465 mm equivalent). The most impressive part is being able to zoom and take photos of objects and people some 100 to 200 metres away and get details you can't see with your eyes. We did run, on the H7, the same chain of tests that we used for the other cameras. The quality of the photos was more or less at par with the Rs 15000–Rs 25,000 group of cameras. Colours seemed a tiny bit



on the darker side. At maximum zoom, there was a fair bit of degradation in quality. Holding the camera still at maximum zoom is another issue with such cameras.

There have been some improvements apart from the megapixel and zoom having been pushed up. The batteries are now Li-ion based, instead of AA NiMH cells. The menus are more user friendly.

If you think about it, the H7 is probably more practical than a SLR; it's much quicker to get running. There is no changing of lenses for the right kind of shot. You can use the manual controls to take the photos—like an SLR—or you can switch to the complete Auto mode if you're in a hurry, and use it like a point-and-shoot camera.

Getting the kind of flexibility the H7 provides on even a D-SLR is a very costly affair. At Rs 22,990, this camera is cheaper than the cheapest D-SLR you can buy today. Unfortunately, there is a downside to all the features and performance. Battery consumption is a little more with such cameras because of the larger motor movements required to move the bulkier lens mechanism. You also end up with a bulkier camera, which can't be shoved into a pocket. The camera is great for any photography enthusiast who can't afford to buy a good D-SLR, or a lens that would be required to match the performance of the DSC H7.